

Questions

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1. Three particles of masses m , $2m$ and km are placed at the points $A(a, 0)$, $B(-2a, 3a)$ and $C(2a, -a)$ respectively, where $k > 0$.

The centre of mass of the three particles is the point with coordinates $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

- (a) (i) Find $\bar{x}$ in terms of a and k .
 (ii) Find $\bar{y}$ in terms of a and k .

[4]

- (b) Given that the centre of mass lies on the circle with centre $(a, 0)$ and radius $\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}a$, find the possible values of k .

[2]

Solution

- (a) The total mass is

$$M = m + 2m + km = (k + 3)m$$

- (i) Using the formula for the x -coordinate of the centre of mass,

$$M\bar{x} = m(a) + 2m(-2a) + km(2a)$$

So

$$\begin{aligned}(k + 3)m\bar{x} &= am - 4am + 2kam \\ &= am(2k - 3)\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\bar{x} = \frac{a(2k - 3)}{k + 3}$$

So the x -coordinate is $\bar{x} = \frac{a(2k - 3)}{k + 3}$.

- (ii) Using the formula for the y -coordinate of the centre of mass,

$$M\bar{y} = m(0) + 2m(3a) + km(-a)$$

So

$$\begin{aligned}(k + 3)m\bar{y} &= 0 + 6am - kam \\ &= am(6 - k)\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\bar{y} = \frac{a(6 - k)}{k + 3}$$

So the y -coordinate is $\bar{y} = \frac{a(6 - k)}{k + 3}$.

- (b) Since the centre of mass lies on the circle with centre $(a, 0)$ and radius $\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}a$,

$$(\bar{x} - a)^2 + \bar{y}^2 = \left(\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}a\right)^2 = \frac{a^2}{2}$$

From part (a),

$$\begin{aligned}\bar{x} - a &= \frac{a(2k - 3)}{k + 3} - a \\ &= a \left(\frac{2k - 3 - (k + 3)}{k + 3} \right) \\ &= \frac{a(k - 6)}{k + 3}\end{aligned}$$

and

$$\bar{y} = \frac{a(6-k)}{k+3} = -\frac{a(k-6)}{k+3}$$

Substituting into the circle equation,

$$\begin{aligned}\left(\frac{a(k-6)}{k+3}\right)^2 + \left(-\frac{a(k-6)}{k+3}\right)^2 &= \frac{a^2}{2} \\ 2\left(\frac{a(k-6)}{k+3}\right)^2 &= \frac{a^2}{2}\end{aligned}$$

So

$$4(k-6)^2 = (k+3)^2$$

Expanding,

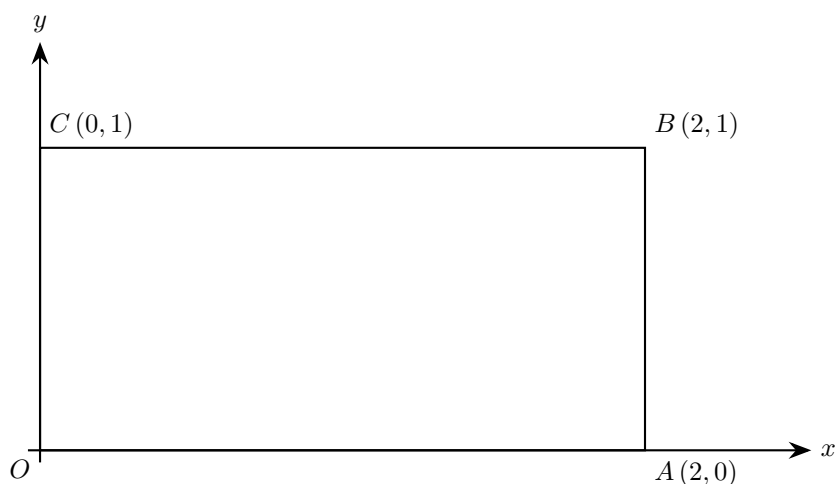
$$\begin{aligned}4(k^2 - 12k + 36) &= k^2 + 6k + 9 \\ 4k^2 - 48k + 144 &= k^2 + 6k + 9 \\ 3k^2 - 54k + 135 &= 0 \\ k^2 - 18k + 45 &= 0\end{aligned}$$

Factorising,

$$(k-3)(k-15) = 0$$

Hence the possible values of k are

$$k = 3 \quad \text{or} \quad k = 15$$



2. The diagram shows a light rectangular lamina $OABC$ where O is the origin of the coordinate system in which the points A , B and C have coordinates $(2, 0)$, $(2, 1)$ and $(0, 1)$ respectively. Coordinates refer to the axes shown and the units are metres.

The following three forces are applied to the lamina.

$$\begin{pmatrix} p \\ 2q \end{pmatrix} \text{ N at the point } (1, 0)$$

$$\begin{pmatrix} -q \\ p \end{pmatrix} \text{ N at the point } C$$

$$\begin{pmatrix} -3 \\ -6 \end{pmatrix} \text{ N at the point } (t, 1), \text{ where } 0 \leq t \leq 2$$

The three forces form a couple of magnitude 3 N m in the anticlockwise direction.

- (a) Determine the values of p , q and t .

[5]

The three forces are removed. The lamina is in the same position as shown in the diagram.

Three particles are now attached to certain points on the lamina as follows.

- (b) Find the coordinates of the composite body's centre of mass. Give your answer in terms of λ , where the particles are
- a particle of mass 2 kg at the point $(2\lambda^2, \lambda)$, where $0 \leq \lambda \leq 1$
 - a particle of mass 1 kg at the point A
 - a particle of mass 1 kg at the point C

[3]

- (c) Show that, as λ varies, the centre of mass of the combined object lies on the curve

$$x = 4y^2 - 2y + k$$

where k is a constant to be determined.

[3]

Solution

- (a) Since the three forces form a couple, their resultant force is zero.

Resolving in the x - and y -directions:

$$p - q - 3 = 0, \quad p + 2q - 6 = 0$$

Subtracting the first equation from the second gives

$$3q - 3 = 0$$

so

$$q = 1.$$

Substituting into $p - q - 3 = 0$:

$$p - 1 - 3 = 0 \implies p = 4.$$

Now take moments about O , with anticlockwise positive.

For a force (F_x, F_y) acting at (x, y) , the moment about O is

$$xF_y - yF_x.$$

So the moments of the three forces are

$$M_1 = 1(2q) - 0(p) = 2q,$$

$$M_2 = 0(p) - 1(-q) = q,$$

$$M_3 = t(-6) - 1(-3) = 3 - 6t.$$

Since the forces form an anticlockwise couple of magnitude 3 N m ,

$$M_1 + M_2 + M_3 = 3.$$

Hence

$$2q + q + 3 - 6t = 3.$$

Using $q = 1$:

$$2 + 1 + 3 - 6t = 3.$$

Therefore

$$6 - 6t = 3 \implies 6t = 3 \implies t = \frac{1}{2}.$$

So

$$p = 4, \quad q = 1, \quad t = \frac{1}{2}.$$

- (b) The lamina is light, so its mass is taken to be zero.

Let the centre of mass of the composite body be (x, y) .

The total mass is

$$2 + 1 + 1 = 4.$$

Using $Mx = M_1x_1 + M_2x_2 + M_3x_3$,

$$4x = 2(2\lambda^2) + 1(2) + 1(0) = 4\lambda^2 + 2.$$

So

$$x = \lambda^2 + \frac{1}{2}.$$

Using $My = M_1y_1 + M_2y_2 + M_3y_3$,

$$4y = 2(\lambda) + 1(0) + 1(1) = 2\lambda + 1.$$

So

$$y = \frac{2\lambda + 1}{4}.$$

Hence the centre of mass is

$$\left(\lambda^2 + \frac{1}{2}, \frac{2\lambda + 1}{4} \right).$$

(c) From part (b), the centre of mass has coordinates

$$x = \lambda^2 + \frac{1}{2}, \quad y = \frac{2\lambda + 1}{4}.$$

Rearranging the expression for y ,

$$4y = 2\lambda + 1$$

so

$$\lambda = \frac{4y - 1}{2}.$$

Substitute this into the expression for x :

$$\begin{aligned} x &= \left(\frac{4y - 1}{2} \right)^2 + \frac{1}{2} \\ &= \frac{16y^2 - 8y + 1}{4} + \frac{1}{2} \\ &= 4y^2 - 2y + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{2} \\ &= 4y^2 - 2y + \frac{3}{4}. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore the locus is

$$x = 4y^2 - 2y + k$$

with

$$k = \frac{3}{4}.$$

3. Three particles of masses $2m$, $5m$ and $3m$ are placed at the points $(1, -4)$, $(-3, 2)$ and $(q, 2q - 1)$ respectively.

The value of q is such that the distance of the centre of mass of the three particles from the point $(1, 0)$ is as small as possible.

Find the value of q .

[7]

Solution

Let the centre of mass be $G(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

The total mass is

$$2m + 5m + 3m = 10m$$

Using the centre of mass formula for the coordinates,

$$10m\bar{x} = 2m(1) + 5m(-3) + 3m(q)$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} 10\bar{x} &= 2 - 15 + 3q \\ \bar{x} &= \frac{3q - 13}{10} \end{aligned}$$

Also,

$$10m\bar{y} = 2m(-4) + 5m(2) + 3m(2q - 1)$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} 10\bar{y} &= -8 + 10 + 6q - 3 \\ &= 6q - 1 \\ \bar{y} &= \frac{6q - 1}{10} \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$G\left(\frac{3q - 13}{10}, \frac{6q - 1}{10}\right)$$

Let the distance from G to $(1, 0)$ be d . Then

$$\begin{aligned} d^2 &= \left(\frac{3q - 13}{10} - 1\right)^2 + \left(\frac{6q - 1}{10}\right)^2 \\ &= \left(\frac{3q - 23}{10}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{6q - 1}{10}\right)^2 \\ &= \frac{(3q - 23)^2 + (6q - 1)^2}{100} \end{aligned}$$

Now expand:

$$\begin{aligned} (3q - 23)^2 + (6q - 1)^2 &= 9q^2 - 138q + 529 + 36q^2 - 12q + 1 \\ &= 45q^2 - 150q + 530 \end{aligned}$$

So

$$d^2 = \frac{45q^2 - 150q + 530}{100}$$

To make d as small as possible, it is enough to make d^2 as small as possible. Complete the square:

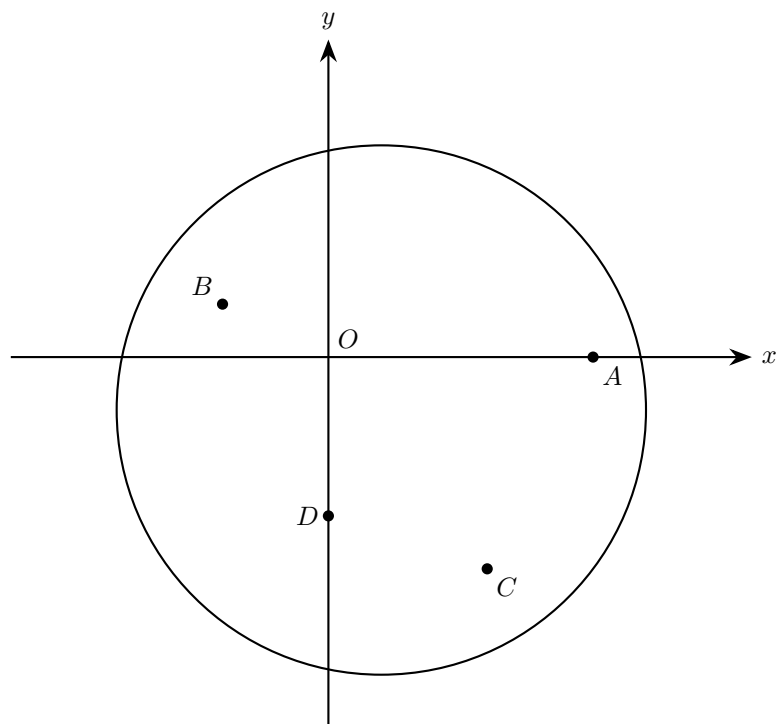
$$\begin{aligned}45q^2 - 150q + 530 &= 45 \left(q^2 - \frac{10}{3}q \right) + 530 \\&= 45 \left[\left(q - \frac{5}{3} \right)^2 - \frac{25}{9} \right] + 530 \\&= 45 \left(q - \frac{5}{3} \right)^2 - 125 + 530 \\&= 45 \left(q - \frac{5}{3} \right)^2 + 405\end{aligned}$$

Since $45 \left(q - \frac{5}{3} \right)^2 \geq 0$, this expression is smallest when

$$q - \frac{5}{3} = 0$$

Therefore,

$$q = \frac{5}{3}$$



4. Four sensors are attached to a circular plate.

The plate is to be modelled as a uniform lamina and the four sensors as four particles.

The diagram shows the lamina, the four particles A , B , C and D , and the coordinate axes.

The lamina has mass 6 kg and its centre of mass is at the point $(1, -1)$.

Particle A has mass 4 kg and is at the point $(5, 0)$.

Particle B has mass 3 kg and is at the point $(-2, 1)$.

Particle C has mass 5 kg and is at the point $(3, -4)$.

Particle D has mass 2 kg and is at the point $(0, -3)$.

Find the coordinates of the centre of mass of the system of plate and sensors.

[5]

Solution

Treat the uniform lamina as a particle of mass 6 kg acting at its centre of mass $(1, -1)$.

Let the centre of mass of the whole system be $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

The total mass is

$$M = 6 + 4 + 3 + 5 + 2 = 20 \text{ kg}$$

For the x -coordinate, use the weighted average

$$M\bar{x} = m_1x_1 + m_2x_2 + m_3x_3 + m_4x_4 + m_5x_5$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} 20\bar{x} &= 6(1) + 4(5) + 3(-2) + 5(3) + 2(0) \\ &= 6 + 20 - 6 + 15 + 0 \\ &= 35 \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\bar{x} = \frac{35}{20} = \frac{7}{4}$$

For the y -coordinate,

$$M\bar{y} = m_1y_1 + m_2y_2 + m_3y_3 + m_4y_4 + m_5y_5$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} 20\bar{y} &= 6(-1) + 4(0) + 3(1) + 5(-4) + 2(-3) \\ &= -6 + 0 + 3 - 20 - 6 \\ &= -29 \end{aligned}$$

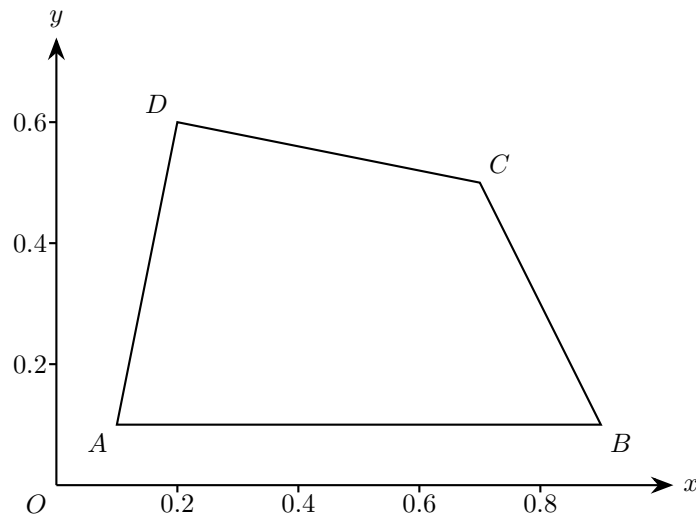
Hence

$$\bar{y} = \frac{-29}{20}$$

Therefore the centre of mass of the system is

$$\left(\frac{7}{4}, -\frac{29}{20}\right)$$

In decimal form, this is $(1.75, -1.45)$.



5. Particles A , B , C and D of masses 1 kg, 2 kg, 3 kg and 4 kg respectively are joined by light rigid rods to form the quadrilateral frame shown in the diagram. The particles are at the points $A(0.1, 0.1)$, $B(0.9, 0.1)$, $C(0.7, 0.5)$ and $D(0.2, 0.6)$, where coordinates are measured in metres.

G , the centre of mass of the frame, has coordinates $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

- (a) Show that $\bar{y} = 0.42$. Find $\bar{x}$. [3]
- (b) Using your answer to part (a), explain why the frame cannot be in equilibrium in a horizontal plane if it is supported by a single peg touching the frame at one point. [1]

Solution

- (a) The total mass of the frame is

$$M = 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 = 10$$

Using the centre of mass formula for particles,

$$M\bar{x} = \sum mx, \quad M\bar{y} = \sum my$$

For the y -coordinate,

$$10\bar{y} = 1(0.1) + 2(0.1) + 3(0.5) + 4(0.6)$$

$$10\bar{y} = 0.1 + 0.2 + 1.5 + 2.4 = 4.2$$

$$\bar{y} = \frac{4.2}{10} = 0.42$$

So $\bar{y} = 0.42$, as required.

For the x -coordinate,

$$10\bar{x} = 1(0.1) + 2(0.9) + 3(0.7) + 4(0.2)$$

$$10\bar{x} = 0.1 + 1.8 + 2.1 + 0.8 = 4.8$$

$$\bar{x} = \frac{4.8}{10} = 0.48$$

Hence the centre of mass is

$$G = (\bar{x}, \bar{y}) = (0.48, 0.42)$$

- (b) For equilibrium on a single peg, the peg must be vertically below the centre of mass. So in the horizontal plane, the peg would have to touch the frame at $G = (0.48, 0.42)$. But this point is not on the frame itself; it lies inside the quadrilateral, not on any of its sides. Therefore the frame cannot be in equilibrium if it is supported by a single peg touching the frame at one point.

6. Four particles of mass m , $2m$, $4m$ and λm are placed at points with coordinates $(0, 0)$, $(2, 3)$, $(1, -1)$ and $(4, 2)$ respectively. The centre of mass of the system is at $(2, k)$.

(a) Show that $\lambda = 3$. [4]

(b) Calculate the value of k . [3]

Solution

(a) Let the total mass be M . Then

$$M = m + 2m + 4m + \lambda m = (7 + \lambda)m$$

Using the x -coordinate of the centre of mass, with centre $(2, k)$,

$$M \cdot 2 = m \cdot 0 + 2m \cdot 2 + 4m \cdot 1 + \lambda m \cdot 4$$

So

$$2(7 + \lambda)m = 0 + 4m + 4m + 4\lambda m$$

$$2(7 + \lambda) = 8 + 4\lambda$$

$$14 + 2\lambda = 8 + 4\lambda$$

$$6 = 2\lambda$$

$$\lambda = 3$$

Hence $\lambda = 3$.

(b) Now use the y -coordinate of the centre of mass. Since $\lambda = 3$,

$$M = (7 + 3)m = 10m$$

Also,

$$M \cdot k = m \cdot 0 + 2m \cdot 3 + 4m \cdot (-1) + 3m \cdot 2$$

So

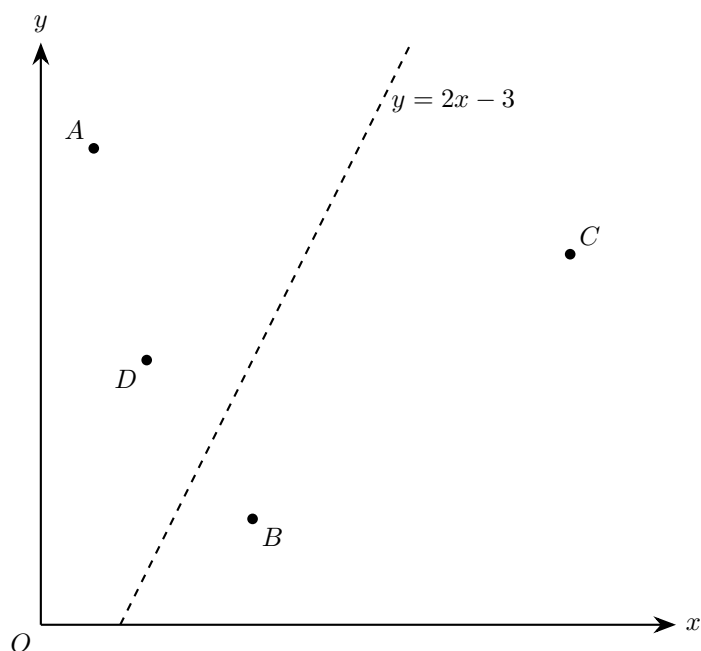
$$10mk = 0 + 6m - 4m + 6m$$

$$10mk = 8m$$

$$k = \frac{8}{10}$$

$$k = \frac{4}{5}$$

So the value of k is $\frac{4}{5}$.



7. The diagram shows four particles, A , B , C and D , fixed in a horizontal plane which contains the x - and y -axes.

Particle A has mass 3 kg and is attached at the point $(1, 9)$.
 Particle B has mass 4 kg and is attached at the point $(4, 2)$.
 Particle C has mass 5 kg and is attached at the point $(10, 7)$.
 Particle D has mass m kg and is attached at the point $(2, 5)$.

The centre of mass of the four particles lies on the line $y = 2x - 3$.
 Find the value of m and the coordinates of the centre of mass.

[6]

Solution

Let the centre of mass be $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

The total mass is

$$M = 3 + 4 + 5 + m = 12 + m$$

Using the centre of mass formula for coordinates,

$$M\bar{x} = 3(1) + 4(4) + 5(10) + m(2)$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} (12 + m)\bar{x} &= 3 + 16 + 50 + 2m \\ &= 69 + 2m \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\bar{x} = \frac{69 + 2m}{12 + m}$$

Similarly,

$$M\bar{y} = 3(9) + 4(2) + 5(7) + m(5)$$

so

$$\begin{aligned} (12 + m)\bar{y} &= 27 + 8 + 35 + 5m \\ &= 70 + 5m \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\bar{y} = \frac{70 + 5m}{12 + m}$$

Since the centre of mass lies on the line $y = 2x - 3$,

$$\frac{70 + 5m}{12 + m} = 2 \left(\frac{69 + 2m}{12 + m} \right) - 3$$

Multiply through by $12 + m$:

$$\begin{aligned} 70 + 5m &= 2(69 + 2m) - 3(12 + m) \\ &= 138 + 4m - 36 - 3m \\ &= 102 + m \end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} 70 + 5m &= 102 + m \\ 4m &= 32 \\ m &= 8 \end{aligned}$$

Now substitute $m = 8$. Then the total mass is

$$12 + 8 = 20$$

So

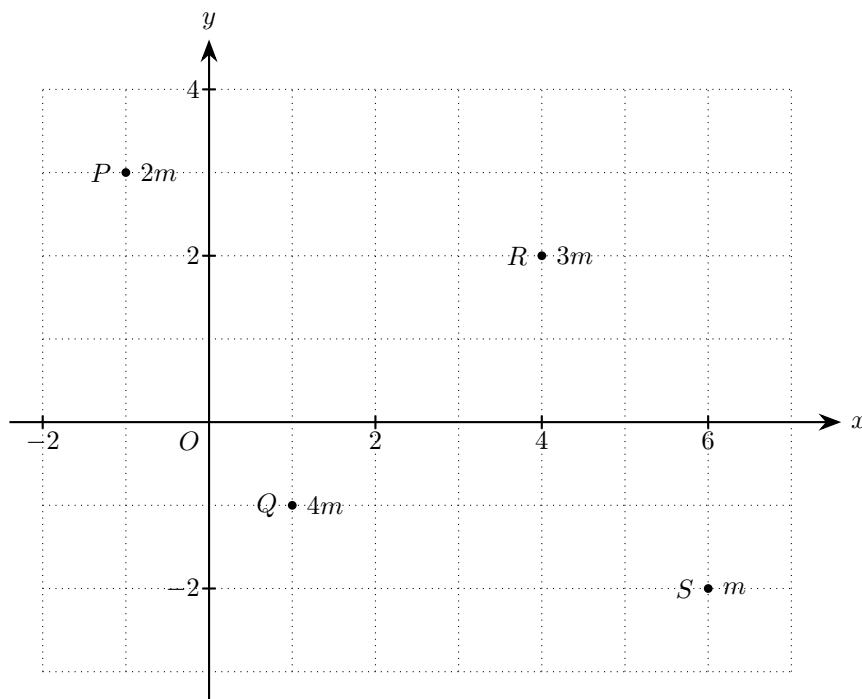
$$\begin{aligned} \bar{x} &= \frac{69 + 2(8)}{20} = \frac{85}{20} = \frac{17}{4} \\ \bar{y} &= \frac{70 + 5(8)}{20} = \frac{110}{20} = \frac{11}{2} \end{aligned}$$

Therefore,

$$m = 8$$

and the centre of mass is

$$\left(\frac{17}{4}, \frac{11}{2} \right)$$



8. The diagram shows a system of four particles of masses $2m$, $4m$, $3m$ and m situated in the x - y plane at the points $P(-1, 3)$, $Q(1, -1)$, $R(4, 2)$ and $S(6, -2)$ respectively.

Find the coordinates of the centre of mass of the system.

[5]

Solution

Let the centre of mass be $(\bar{x}, \bar{y})$.

First find the total mass:

$$M = 2m + 4m + 3m + m = 10m$$

For the x -coordinate of the centre of mass, use the weighted average:

$$M\bar{x} = 2m(-1) + 4m(1) + 3m(4) + m(6)$$

So

$$10m\bar{x} = -2m + 4m + 12m + 6m = 20m$$

Hence

$$\bar{x} = 2$$

For the y -coordinate of the centre of mass:

$$M\bar{y} = 2m(3) + 4m(-1) + 3m(2) + m(-2)$$

So

$$10m\bar{y} = 6m - 4m + 6m - 2m = 6m$$

Hence

$$\bar{y} = \frac{3}{5}$$

Therefore the coordinates of the centre of mass are $(2, \frac{3}{5})$.

9. Four particles of masses m , $2m$, $3m$ and km are positioned at the points with coordinates $(-a, a)$, $(2a, -2a)$, $(0, 0)$ and $(\mu a, 2\mu a)$ respectively, where k and μ are constants.

The centre of mass of the four particles is at the point with coordinates $(2a, 3a)$.

(a) Find the value of k . [3]

(b) Find the value of μ . [3]

Solution

(a) Let the total mass be

$$M = m + 2m + 3m + km = (6 + k)m$$

Using the formula for the x -coordinate of the centre of mass,

$$M(2a) = m(-a) + 2m(2a) + 3m(0) + km(\mu a)$$

so

$$(6 + k)m(2a) = -am + 4am + 0 + k\mu am$$

$$2(6 + k) = 3 + k\mu$$

$$12 + 2k = 3 + k\mu$$

$$k\mu = 9 + 2k$$

Using the formula for the y -coordinate of the centre of mass,

$$M(3a) = m(a) + 2m(-2a) + 3m(0) + km(2\mu a)$$

so

$$(6 + k)m(3a) = am - 4am + 0 + 2k\mu am$$

$$3(6 + k) = -3 + 2k\mu$$

$$18 + 3k = -3 + 2k\mu$$

$$2k\mu = 21 + 3k$$

Now double the equation $k\mu = 9 + 2k$:

$$2k\mu = 18 + 4k$$

Equating the two expressions for $2k\mu$,

$$18 + 4k = 21 + 3k$$

$$k = 3$$

Hence $k = 3$.

(b) Substitute $k = 3$ into

$$k\mu = 9 + 2k$$

to get

$$3\mu = 9 + 2(3)$$

$$3\mu = 15$$

$$\mu = 5$$

Hence $\mu = 5$.